Overview of the Movement Philosophy and Movement Resources

THE SYNERGY OF MINDFUL MOVEMENT AND MEDITATION

Mindfulness practices help you guide your attention back to the direct experience in your body. For many, sitting practice is both subtle and challenging. Mindful movement can be an excellent supportive practice.

Mindful movement can provide a wonderful way to:

- Provide a tool for concentration and inner focus
- Release tension and prepare for sitting meditation
- Provide an experience that can energize and settle a group of students

ABOUT THE MOVEMENT FLOWS YOU'LL LEARN IN THIS COURSE

Over the course of this training you'll learn six movement flows of about four to eight minutes you can offer your students. You will learn three sequences for standing and three sequences for sitting on a chair. You won't be learning any sequences done on the floor as this requires clean floors, yoga mats, and other accoutrement you may not have handy.

The movement flows are designed to be simple to perform for most people and have few contraindications. Despite their simplicity, they can be profoundly helpful for preparing your students for meditation.

THE IMPORTANCE OF LONG, SLOW, SMOOTH BREATHS

Slow, smooth, and conscious breathing is key to cultivating greater awareness of the senses. Encourage your students to slow down and smooth out the breath, ideally about five breaths per minute. This can be achieved by counting slowly to five on the inhalation and exhalation. Matching the length of the inhalation and exhalation will help enhance awareness.

Slow, deep, and smooth breathing has always been an important aspect of practicing yoga and has been proven to stimulate the parasympathetic nervous system and cultivate calm.

HOLDING THE POSTURE

The benefit of holding a pose extends far beyond stretching the muscles. It affects both muscles and connective tissue and can stimulate an internal relaxation response.

The goal is to hold each posture for at least one minute with long, smooth and flowing breath, but advise your students not to strain. Encourage them to "find their sweet spot" and not to push beyond 75 percent of what they think they are capable of stretching.

CHALLENGES AND CONTRAINDICATIONS FOR MOVEMENT

Almost any movement can pose challenges for some and have some contraindications. You can support your students' physical safety by encouraging them to:

- Listen to their body's feedback and not force a stretch
- Maintain slow deep breathing, as this will help them stay more aware of their inner experience
- Modify any posture in a way they feel safe
- Release any stretch they are holding when they feel the need

THE IMPORTANCE OF THE DEMO

As some of your students will be brand new to these flows, it's important you demonstrate each pose so they can clearly see what you are asking them to do. Point out the key areas to focus on and encourage them to make any adjustments they need to stay comfortable.

You will be provided a script with key points to emphasize.

A NOTE ABOUT TEACHING MOVEMENT

Learning these movement flows does not qualify you as a yoga teacher or as a certified movement professional. They are suggested sequences you may find helpful to offer your students. If you are drawn to learn more about mindful movement, we highly suggest you get formal training and certification.

Many people have physical limitations. Rather than offer any advice about what postures to do or not do, recommend they seek professional help.

TO LEARN MORE

Attending a yoga or qigong class will help you learn language and pacing.

Much of these flows are informed by the work of Lee Albert and his book *Yoga for Pain Relief,* dudleycourtpress.com/books/yoga-for-pain-relief-lee-albert/

Yoga for Dummies, by the scholar Georg Feurstein, offers an excellent overview of mindful movement.